

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mrs Maria Moheb

Address: 3 Westerham Close Sutton SM2 6NQ

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am writing to support the proposed development at the former ambulance station on Dorset Road. Application DM2025/01591 represents a sensible and beneficial use of this vacant site.

Residents will no longer have emergency vehicles coming and going through the night. The facility will operate within defined hours, which is a considerable improvement over the former ambulance station that ran 24 hours a day, seven days a week.

I would ask objectors to consider what they are comparing this proposal against. The site was not a quiet park. It was an operational ambulance station running 24 hours a day. The proposed use is calmer, quieter, and more controlled in every respect.

The scale of the proposed works is restrained. The external greening will soften the appearance of the site. The extension does not dominate the site or the street scene, and the height increase is limited to improving the internal functionality of the building.

Furthermore, the noise report confirms what common sense suggests: this is a quieter use of the site. A 24-hour ambulance station with sirens and heavy vehicles was considerably noisier than a community facility operating within defined hours.

I'd also add that the application demonstrates a clear and growing need for this type of facility in the area. The demographic evidence is compelling, and the existing provision is simply not sufficient. This proposal addresses an obvious gap.

It is also worth mentioning that the community hub aspect of this application should not be overlooked. It provides something that the area currently lacks: a local, accessible space where residents of all backgrounds can participate in educational, social, and wellbeing activities.

I hope the Council will focus on what matters in planning terms: whether this is the right use for this site, whether it is well-designed, and whether its impacts are acceptable. The application documents demonstrate convincingly that the answer to all three is yes.

In addition, the environmental assessments submitted with this application show that the development has been planned responsibly. The Biodiversity Net Gain requirement is met, flood risk has been assessed, and the energy strategy has been considered. This is a well-rounded application.

It is also worth mentioning that a survey during the peak Friday prayer period found on-street parking at less than 50% capacity in the surrounding area. I have read the Transport Statement and the parking evidence is convincing. The worst-case modelling still leaves 66 spaces available and stays well under the 85% parking stress threshold.

In addition, objectors seem to have missed that the previous use had 21 parking spaces on site. The development reduces this number, not increases it. Additionally, the yellow lines that currently restrict on-street parking near the entrance will be removed, giving residents more kerbside space than they have now.

I'd also add that the Transport Statement has addressed this directly and the evidence is clear. I understand why parents might worry about school-run congestion, but the timings of Friday prayers simply do not overlap with school drop-off or pick-up.

The link between community participation and better health outcomes is not disputed. What is often lacking is the local infrastructure to make participation possible. This proposal provides that infrastructure in an area where it is currently missing.

The inclusion of dedicated women's facilities and family-friendly spaces is an important aspect of this proposal. This facility would change that. Many women in the area, particularly those with young children or those who do not drive, currently lack accessible local community provision.

I note that the travel survey data demonstrates a very low rate of single-occupancy car use among the congregation. Most people walk. The transport impact of this facility is modest. The addition of cycle storage will support this further.

The NPPF requires planning authorities to plan positively for community infrastructure. This application is supported at every level of the policy hierarchy, and I would expect the Council to

give that due weight. Sutton's Local Plan echoes this requirement.

This is a 0.12 hectare brownfield site that has been empty since the ambulance service left. The proposal brings it back into active use for the community. I cannot see any planning reason to prefer a vacant, deteriorating site over a well-managed community facility.

I respectfully request that the London Borough of Sutton grants planning permission for DM2025/01591. This is a proposal that will make the neighbourhood better.